The Skunk Ladder

By Patrick F.McManus

PAT *(to audience):* Driving out to the country the other day, my wife, Bun, and I passed the aromatic remains of at least ten road-killed skunks. *(to Bun)* Must be a good year for skunks

BUN: Looks like a bad one for them, if you ask me.

PAT *(to Bun):* I mean there's obviously a large skunk population this year. *(to audience)* Just then a live skunk scurried out in front of the car. I swerved to the left and back to the right, and we managed to screech safely around it.

BUN: Goodness, that was close! What would you have done if you'd hit that skunk with the car?

PAT: The only decent thing. I'd have stopped and buried it in the ditch. I might even have buried the skunk along with it.

BUN: You talk as if you've had a lot of experience with skunks

PAT: You bet. Mostly when I was a kid. You mean I've never told you about the skunk ladder? Boy do you have a treat in store for you!

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INTRODUCTION

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PAT: My friend Crazy Eddie Muldoon and I were sitting on the corral fence one summer afternoon, trying to think of something to do. Mr. Muldoon came by on his tractor and stopped to study us suspiciously.

MR. MULDOON: What are you two up to now?

EDDIE: Just trying to think of something to do.

MR. MULDOON: Well, when you think of it, you let me know before you start to do it, you hear?

EDDIE: Sure, Pa. I guess what we'll do is go dig in the dirt. We've been talkin' about doin' that.

MR. MULDOON: Okay. Just don't build nothing!

PAT: *(to audience)* Then he drove off. *(to Eddie)* What kind of hole are we going to dig? *(to audience)* He stared off into space, his face enveloped in that dreamy expression that always accompanied one of his wondrous new ideas.

EDDIE: A big hole. A real big hole.

PAT: There are basically two kinds of holes: (1) applied holes such as for posts, wells, mines, etc. and 2) holes for holes' sake. Eddie and I were digging one of the latter. Digging the hole occupied us for most of a week. Eventually, the hole was so deep we could barely heave shovelfuls of dirt up over its sides. And since Eddie had insisted that we keep the sides of the hole squared up, we had to pull ourselves out of it on a rope, one end of which was tied to a pile of stumps nearby. We were immensely proud of the hole. It was so nice, in fact, that Eddie began trying to think of it as practical.

EDDIE: You know what we could do with this hole? We could make a wild animal trap out of it, you know, like in Africa. We could cover it up with branches and leaves and grass, and wild animals would come along and fall into it. Then we could tame them and teach them to do tricks. . . . And then we could start our own circus. We could charge people. We might even get rich. Gosh, I bet we could catch a deer or an elk or a bear or a mountain lion or . . .

PAT: One of your father's cows.

EDDIE: Yeah, I never thought of that . . . Tomorrow we'd better fill the hole back in.

PAT: How about tonight? Maybe a cow will fall in tonight.

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EDDIE: I got it. There's a big ol' door out behind the barn. We'll drag that down here and put it over the hole.

PAT: And that is what we did. Secure in the knowledge that the door would save us from the uncomfortable experience of watching his father undergo one of his fits of hysteria. Early the next morning, Eddie and I headed for the big hole, prepared to start the tedious task of undigging it. As we approached the excavation, a familiar odor reached our nostrils.

EDDIE: Must be a skunk around here someplace.

PAT: Maybe it's in thehole.

EDDIE: Couldn't be. We covered it with the door.

PAT: *(to audience)* Nevertheless, the skunk was in the hole. He had found an open space under the door, slipped in for a look around and plummeted the eight feet or more to the bottom. Oddly, for we did not know that skunks were great diggers, he had hollowed out a huge covern under one side, in an attempt to dig his way out of the hole. *(to Eddie)* We can't fill in the hole with the skunk in there. How are we going to get him out?

EDDIE: Maybe one of us could drop down in the hole, grab him real quick before he sprays, and then throw him out. I'll yell real loud so he'll look at me and won't notice when you jump in and grab him and . . .

PAT: I don't like that idea. Think of something else.

EDDIE: I got it! We'll go up to my dad's shop and build a ladder. Then we'll stick it down the hold and hide someplace while he climbs the ladder. A skunk should be able to figure out how to climb a ladder.

PAT: Eddie and I were working on the ladder when his father walked into the shop.

MR. MULDOON: I thought I told you not to build anything. What's that?

EDDIE: Just a skunk ladder.

MR. MULDOON: Oh, well, don't build nothin' else unless you tell me first.

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PAT: Eddie and I went back out to the hold and stuck the ladder in it. The skunk showed no inclination to climb it, choosing instead to hide in the cavern it had hollowed out. Just then we heard Eddie's father yelling . . . .

MR. MULDOON: What did you mean, skunk ladder?

EDDIE: Quick, help me put the door back over the hole!

PAT: We threw the door over the top of the hole, neatly hiding it from view.

MR. MULDOON: Now what? Where did that dirt come from? What's my door doing out here?

PAT: He reached down and grabbed the edge of the door.

EDDIE: Stop, Pa, don't!

PAT: From that point on, the actions of the parties involved all blurred together. Mr. Muldoon grabbed the door and flipped it off the hole.

MR. MULDOON: Smells like a skun . . . .

PAT: At which time he shot out of sight. A cloud of dust puffed up out of the hole when Mr. Muldoon hit the bottom. Then he yelled several serious swear words with the word

MR. MULDOON: SKUNK!

PAT: mixed in with them. Next there were a lot of earthy scrabbling sounds, and Mr. Muldoon came clawing his way up the side of the hole, but the dirt gae way and he fell back in saying something like

MR. MULDOON: Oooffff!

EDDIE: Pa, Pa, don't hurt him!

PAT: He was standing at the top of the ladder when the skunk rushed up and emerged from the cloud of dust. Startled and not wanting the skunk to reverse ends and spray him, Eddie grabbed the animal by the head. The skunk started scratching and biting, so Eddie threw it back down in the hole, where its arrival was followed by a savage bellow from Mr. Muldoon, who came racing up the skunk ladder

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himself. This was the signal for Eddie and me to start running. Eddie eventually made his way home and placed himself under the protective custody of his mother. In the ruckus at the skunk ladder, Eddie had been hit in the face with a slight charge of skunk spray. Worried at first that the spray might have affected his brain, Mr. and Mrs. Muldoon finally assumed there would be no lasting ill effects. Twenty years later, however, Crazy Eddie became a Ph.D. in chemistry!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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